

IMMIGRATION

Teenaged Mexican immigrant dies in ICE detention

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By **Syra Ortiz Blanes** and **Claire Healy**

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A photo of Royer Perez-Jimenez published by Volusia County Corrections *Volusia County*

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A 19-year-old Mexican man died on Monday of what authorities said was “presumed suicide” in Immigration and Customs Enforcement detention, the agency announced, marking the 13th death nationwide this year.

Royer Perez-Jimenez was found “unconscious and unresponsive” by a detention officer at 2:34 a.m., [according to a press release](#). The report states that, after medical services’ attempts at resuscitation were unsuccessful, he was pronounced dead at 2:51 a.m.

“He died of a presumed suicide; however, the official cause of his death remains under investigation,” the agency said.

Since President Donald Trump returned to office, Perez-Jimenez is the eighth person to die in immigration detention Florida. So far, over 40 people have died nationwide in ICE custody during the Trump administration. The death toll ranges from two men killed by an active shooter at an ICE office in Dallas to people who have died from natural causes. So far in March alone at least five people have died while in ICE custody, according to government press releases.

The incident captured the attention of Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum, who said her country is investigating. She called his death “deeply regrettable,” and told reporters that Mexico City was sending a strongly worded diplomatic letter to the United States and that the foreign ministry was analyzing “several measures” in response.

“The report states that the young man committed suicide. However, we want a thorough investigation,” Sheinbaum said during [a press conference in Cancun](#). “And furthermore, it is unacceptable that something like this is happening.”

Perez-Jimenez’s father, [speaking to Mexican media](#), said that the teen had left his home in the state of Chiapas for the U.S. at age 15, hoping to make money and

have his own home.

“Send me his body,” his father said, when asked what he would want from the Mexican consulate.

Perez-Jimenez entered ICE custody on Feb. 21, the release states, less than a month before his death. During his medical intake, the agency said he said “no” to all suicide screening questions and denied behavioral issues and concerns. The Miami Herald has requested the autopsy report from the medical examiner’s office.

Under the Trump administration, ICE has started focusing on the criminal histories of detainees as part of their death announcements. Perez-Jimenez came into the United States in February 2022, the agency said, but he voluntarily returned to Mexico that same day after border authorities came across him. It is not known when he returned to the U.S.

The Herald located court and police records matching the ICE notice for a man city of Edgewater officers pulled over for crossing lanes while driving a scooter on Jan. 21.

A snippet from the Jan. 21, 2026 arrest report of Perez-Jimenez. Volusia County court records

He sped away, and when police came across him again a short distance away, he stopped on the sidewalk. An officer ordered him to step off the scooter and sit on

the ground – but it's unclear if he understood, as the officers later had to call for a translator.

When Perez-Jimenez failed to get off the scooter, an officer “attempted to escort the male subject to the ground.” He tensed up and pulled away, the report said, and the officer “attempted a leg sweep to take the subject to the ground.”

On the ground, Perez-Jimenez pulled away and put his hands under his body, the report said. The officers arrested him for resisting an officer without violence.

During a later interview, Perez-Jimenez gave police a false name. He was charged with two misdemeanors for impersonating someone else and resisting an officer, according to the report. Another individual whom officers came across and who was “dressed exactly the same as the first male, coming in from the same location, riding on the exact same make/model scooter,” was also arrested for giving cops a false name.

The next day, on Jan. 22, the Department of Homeland Security filed an immigration detainer requesting that Perez-Jimenez be released into ICE custody. The request noted him as posing “a risk to national security, border security, or public safety.”

☐ Upon completion of the proceeding or investigation for which the individual was transferred to your custody, DHS intends to resume custody of the individual to complete processing and/or make an admissibility determination.

Consistent with “the policy of the United States to faithfully execute the immigration laws against all inadmissible and removable aliens, particularly those aliens who threaten the safety or security of the American people,” set forth in Executive Order 14159, Protecting the American People Against Invasion, DHS requests cooperation regarding the subject who:

☐ illegally reentered the United States after a prior removal;

☒ is subject to the detainer provision of the Laken Riley Act and is required to be effectively and expeditiously taken into custody by DHS pursuant to 8 U.S.C. § 1226(c)(3);

☐ is a member of a designated foreign terrorist organization; and/or

☒ otherwise poses a risk to national security, border security, or public safety.

IT IS THEREFORE REQUESTED THAT YOU:

- **Serve the individual** a copy of this form, and complete and return to ICE the service information at the bottom of this form. If the detainer is not served, the detainer is not valid and may not be relied upon to maintain custody of the individual.
- **Notify DHS** as early as practicable (at least 48 hours, if possible) before the individual is released from your custody. Please notify DHS by calling ☒ U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) or ☐ U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) at

FILED
IN OPEN COURT
JAN 22 2026
Clerk Circuit & County
Court Volusia County, FL

A snippet from Jimenez-Perez's Homeland Security detainer *Volusia County court records*

On Feb. 19, Perez-Jimenez pleaded no contest and was found guilty on both charges, according to court records. He was transferred into ICE custody two days later.

In the case of a Cuban man who died in Texas on Jan. 3, DHS said that he had been placed in segregation after he had become disruptive while in line for medication. DHS [said that staff observed](#) the man in distress while in segregation and called emergency services, and died “after experiencing medical distress”. A medical examiner later [concluded the death was a homicide](#). Witnesses told [the Washington Post](#) and his family that Geraldo Lunas Campos, 55, died after a struggle with guards.

Emanuel Cleeford Damas, a 56-year-old man from Haiti, [died on Mar. 6](#) at a hospital in Arizona after nearly six months in custody. ICE said that doctors who treated him there ruled the preliminary cause of death as unknown, and that physicians days prior had said a likely diagnosis for his serious condition could be septic shock due to pneumonia. But his [family told the Haitian Times](#) that he died from a tooth infection that doctors treated too late.

ICE repeatedly emphasizes in death notifications that it’s committed to offering comprehensive medical care. Following media reports of poor medical care, the Department of Homeland Security [said last month](#) that “the medical care in ICE detention is the best care they have received in their entire lives.”

But the number of deaths has caused widespread alarm nationwide.

Lawyers, advocates and community leaders have long criticized healthcare and living conditions at ICE facilities across the United States. Those criticisms have sharpened under President Trump, as detainee population and deaths have exponentially increased. There were 57,501 people in ICE custody on Feb. 7, 2026, [according to Syracuse University researchers](#), compared to 19,304 Feb. 9, 2025.

[READ MORE: Two men in ICE custody died of ‘natural’ causes. Were their deaths preventable?](#)

Last year, the Herald investigated the deaths of a Ukrainian stroke victim and a Honduran man after they were detained at Krome North Service Processing Center. While the Miami-Dade Medical Examiner Department ruled that both men died of natural causes, the Herald found evidence of what experts described as questionable medical care.

The Glades County Sheriff, whose office operates the facility through a contract with ICE, declined to comment about Perez-Jimenez's death.

The Glades County Sheriff's Office [started holding up to 500 immigrants for ICE under a contract with the agency](#) in April 2025, three years after the Biden administration halted the contract, citing "persistent and ongoing concerns" about detainee healthcare. For years, activists had pushed the federal government to stop working with the facility to house immigrants.

[READ MORE: Guatemalan immigrant being held in Miami dies while in ICE detention](#)

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